Origin and Area of cultivation: It is indigenous to Western Ghats of India. Pepper is one of the most important Indian spices referred to as the "King of Spices" and also termed as "Black Gold of India". Kerala, Karnataka and Tamil Nadu are the top producers in India.

The characteristic pungency of the pepper is due to the presence of alkaloid Piperine. There are two types of pepper available in the market namely black and white pepper.

Uses

It is used for flavouring in the preparation of sauces, soups, curry powder and pickles. It is used in medicine as an aromatic stimulant for enhancing salivary and gastric secretions and also as a stomachic. Pepper also enhances the bio-absorption of medicines.

Turmeric

Botanical name : *Curcuma longa*

Family : Zingiberaceae

Origin and Area of cultivation: It is indigenous to Southern Asia India is the largest producer, consumer and exporter of turmeric. Erode in Tamil Nadu is the World's largest wholesale turmeric market.

Uses

Turmeric is one of the most important and ancient Indian spices and used traditionally over thousands of years for culinary, cosmetic, dyeing and for medicinal purposes. It is an important constituent of curry powders. Turmeric is used as a colouring agent in pharmacy, confectionery and food industry. Rice coloured with turmeric (yellow) is considered sacred and auspicious which is used in ceremonies. It is also used for dyeing leather, fibre, paper and toys.

Curcumin extracted from turmeric is responsible for the yellow colour. Curcumin is a very good anti-oxidant which may help fight various kinds of cancer. It has anti-inflammatory, anti-diabetic, anti-bacterial, anti-fungal and anti-viral activities. It stops platelets from clotting in arteries, which leads to heart attack.

Chillies / Red Pepper

Botanical name : *Capsicum annuum, C. frutescens*.

Family : Solanaceae

Origin and Area of cultivation: Capsicum is native to South America and is popularly known as chillies or red pepper in English. India is leading producer and exporter. *C. annuum* and *C. frutescens* are important cultivated species of chillies.

Uses

The fruits of *C.annuum* are less pungent than the fruits of *C.frutescens*. *C.annum* includes large, sweet bell peppers. Long fruit cultivars of this species are commercially known as 'Cayenne pepper' which are crushed, powdered and used as condiment. Chillies are used in manufacture of sauces, curry powders and preparation of pickles. Capsaicin is an active component of chillies. It has pain relieving properties and used in pain relieving balms. Chillies are a good source of Vitamin C, A and E.



Capsaicin is responsible for the pungency or spicy taste of chillies. Pungency of Chillies is measured in Scoville Heat Units (SHU). World's hottest chilli, Carolina reaper pepper measures 2,200,000 SHU. Naga viper chilli is the hottest in India that measures 1,349,000 SHU. Commonly used cayenne pepper measures 30,000 to 50,000 SHU.

Condiment

Tamarind

Botanical name: *Tamarindus indica*

Family : Fabaceae-Caesalpinioideae



Figure 10.11 : Tamarind

Origin and Area of cultivation: Tamarind is native of tropical African region and was

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